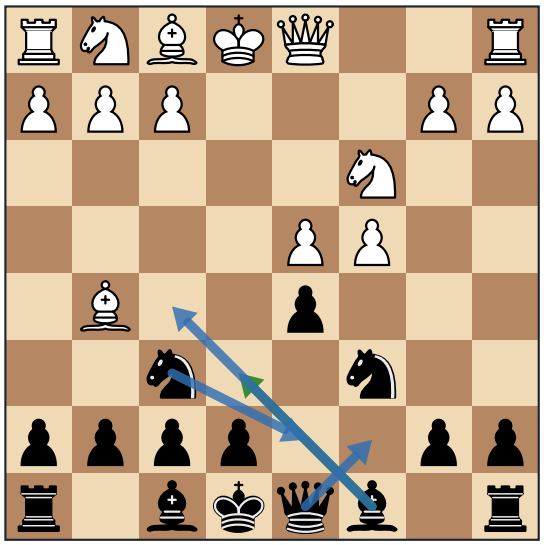
Caro-Kann Defense

ECO B10-B19 | 110 named lines | Caro-Kann family

In one sentence: Rock-solid but not passive: Black keeps a healthy structure and a free light bishop and heads for a comfortable endgame.

Memory pattern: c6, d5, free the bishop, then ...e6 and ...c5.



Main line: 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bg5

Key ideas

1. Support d5 with c6, then develop the light bishop before ...e6.
2. Classical: ...Bf5, ...Nd7, ...Ngf6 and a safe, healthy structure.
3. Advance: attack the chain with ...c5 and ...Nc6 rather than waiting.
4. Panov: play for piece activity against the IQP.
5. Exchange: easy equality; use the half-open c-file.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.08** (equal, depth 16). Best: Be6.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Solid c6/d5 with a free light bishop (Classical) or a French-like chain (Advance). Black has no weaknesses and the endgame is comfortable.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles kingside after ...Be7 and ...Nf6; White's h-pawn push is the main king-attack idea.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bf5/g6 outside the chain, Nd7/Nf6, Qc7. White: Nf3, Bd3, Bf4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black plays ...c5 or ...e5 to free the position; White uses space, or an IQP attack in the Panov.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a space edge and kingside pressure; Black wants safe development, then a pawn break.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bg5

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... c6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2... d5	Challenge e4. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. exd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
3... cxd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
4. c4	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
5. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
5... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
6. Bg5	Develops the bishop to g5.



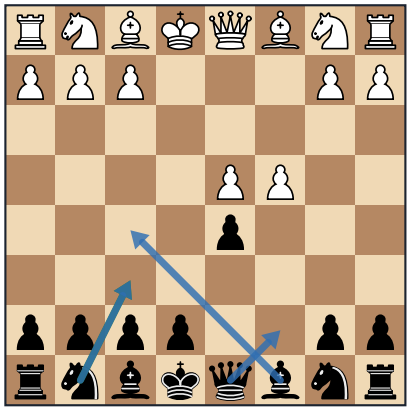
After 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5



After 5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

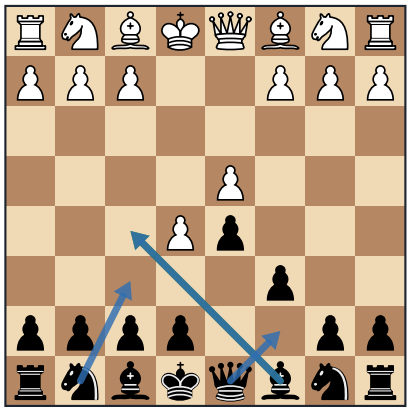


Position after the line

Panov Attack B13 | 15 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4`

Stockfish: **+0.22** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: d5 (challenge e4); dxe4 (release tension); Bf5 (develop outside the chain)
Sub-variations: Modern Defense, Fianchetto Defense, Gunderam Attack, Main Line

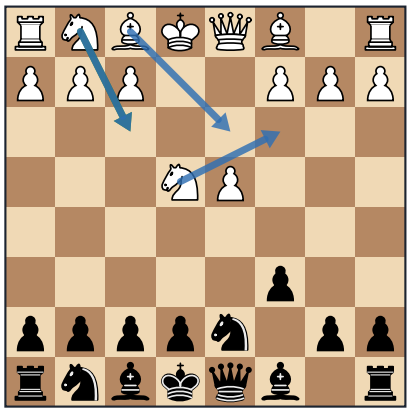


Position after the line

Advance Variation B12 | 10 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5`

Stockfish: **+0.31** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bf5.
What to look for: d5 (challenge e4); dxe4 (release tension); Bf5 (develop outside the chain)
Sub-variations: Van der Wiel Attack, Bayonet Attack, Botvinnik-Carls Defense, Bronstein Variation

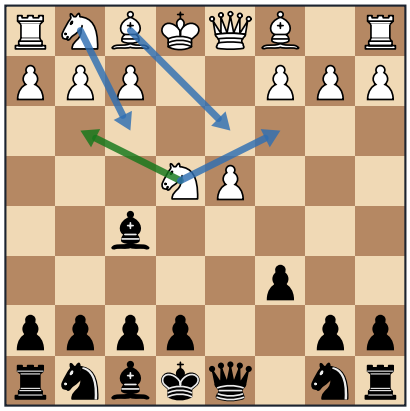


Position after the line

Karpov Variation B17 | 8 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7`

Stockfish: **+0.46** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); e5 (gain space); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Modern Variation, Smyslov Variation, Modern Main Line, Tiviakov-Fischer Attack

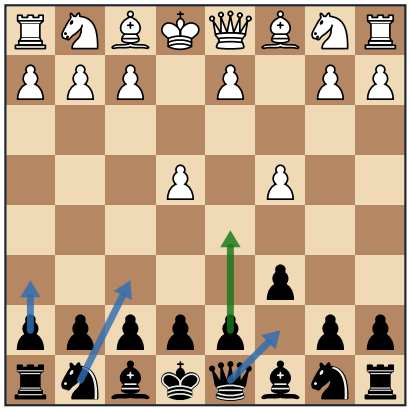


Position after the line

Classical Variation B18 | 8 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5`

Stockfish: **+0.23** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Ng3.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); e5 (gain space); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Flohr Variation, Main Line, Maróczy Attack, Lobron System

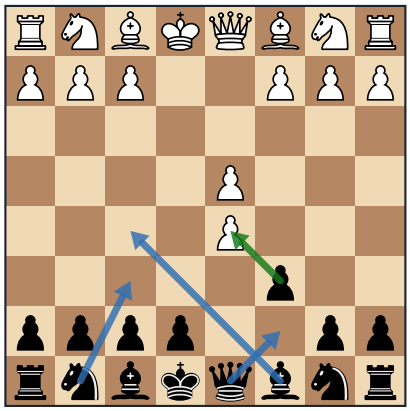


Position after the line

Accelerated Panov Attack B10 | 6 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.c4`

Stockfish: **+0.17** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: d5 (challenge e4); dxe4 (release tension); Bf5 (develop outside the chain)
Sub-variations: Modern Variation, Open Variation, Pseudo-Scandinavian, Van Weersel Attack



Position after the line

Exchange Variation B13 | 6 lines

`1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5`

Stockfish: **+0.19** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: cxd5.
What to look for: d5 (challenge e4); dxe4 (release tension); Bf5 (develop outside the chain)
Sub-variations: Bulla Attack, Rubinstein Variation

Detailed repertoire notes

Caro-Kann (B10-B19, Black)

```
1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4 h6 7.Nf3 Nd7 8.h5 Bh7 9.Bd3 Bxd3 10.Qxd3 e6 11.Bf4
Ngf6 12.O-O-O Be7 13.Kb1 O-O 14.Ne4 Nxe4 15.Qxe4 Nf6
```

Idea: Support d5 with c6, develop the light bishop before ...e6, and play with a healthy pawn structure.

Structure: Classical: Black has c6/e6 with no weaknesses. Advance: White gets space, Black counters with ...c5.

Pieces: Bf5/g6 out early, knights f6/d7, queen c7/d8, rooks c8/d8. Dark bishop e7 or d6 as needed.

Plan: Develop ...Nf6/Nd7, ...e6, ...Bd6 or Be7, then strike with ...c5 or ...e5. In the Advance, challenge the chain with ...c5.

King: Castle after ...Be7/...Nf6; counterplay starts on the queenside. **Opponent:** Space (e5 Advance) or h4-h5 + Bd3 kingside pressure; in the Panov, use the IQP.

Watch out: In the Panov (4.c4), avoid a passive IQP structure; choose active piece play.

Expert and coach view

Capablanca, Petrosian and Karpov are among the great Caro-Kann players.

What a coach would tell you

The Caro-Kann is ideal if you like solid structures. Know your plan against each main reply: Advance (...c5, ...Bf5), Exchange (...Nc6, ...Bg4) and Classical (...Bf5 and ...e6). Aim for a safe middlegame and use the endgame edge.

Why play it

Rock-solid but not passive: Black keeps a healthy structure and a free light bishop and heads for a comfortable endgame.

Typical mistakes

- Playing ...e6 before the light bishop is out.
- Pushing ...h6 and ...Bh7 without a plan against White's h4-h5 push.
- Being too passive against the Advance Variation and getting squeezed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Nd6+ or Nxf7 tricks if the e-pawn is advanced and the king is stuck.
- A Qa4 or Qb3 pin when Black's ...Bf5 hangs the b7 pawn.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Endgames are Black's strength; White gets space but few targets.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Caro-Kann Defense (all lines)** — B10
  `1.e4 c6`
  - **Accelerated Panov Attack** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.c4`
    - **Open Variation** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.c4 -> 2...e5`
    - **Pseudo-Scandinavian** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.c4 -> 2...d5 3.exd5 Qxd5`
    - **Van Weersel Attack** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.c4 -> 2...d5 3.cxd5 cxd5 4.Qb3`
    - **Modern Variation** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.c4 -> 2...d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.cxd5 Nf6`
  - **Breyer Variation** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.d3`
    - **Stein Attack** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.d3 -> 2...d5 3.Nd2 g6 4.Ngf3 Bg7 5.g3 e5 6.Bg2 Ne7 7.O-O O-O 8.b4`
  - **Euwe Attack** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.b3`
  - **Hillbilly Attack** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.Bc4`
    - **Schaeffer Gambit** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.Bc4 -> 2...d5 3.Bb3 dxe4 4.Qh5`
  - **Labahn Attack** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.b4`
    - **Double Gambit** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.b4 -> 2...d5 3.b5`
    - **Polish Variation** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.b4 -> 2...e5 3.Bb2`
  - **Spike Variation** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.g4`
    - **Scorpion-Grob Gambit** — B10
      `1.e4 c6 2.g4 -> 2...d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.d3`
  - **De Bruycker Defense** — B12
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 Na6`
  - **Masi Variation** — B12
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 Nf6`
  - **Massachusetts Defense** — B12
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 f5`
  - **Advance Variation** — B12
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.e5`
    - **Botvinnik-Carls Defense** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...c5`
    - **Bayonet Attack** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.g4`
    - **Bronstein Variation** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.Ne2`
    - **Prins Attack** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.b4`
    - **Short Variation** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.Nf3`
    - **Tal Variation** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.h4`
    - **Van der Wiel Attack** — B12
      `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 -> 3...Bf5 4.Nc3`
      - **Dreyev Defense** — B12
        `1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 Bf5 4.Nc3 -> 4...Qb6`
  - **Endgame Offer** — B10
    `1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nf3 d5 3.d3`

- **Exchange Variation** B13
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.exd5
  - **Bulla Attack** B13
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 -> 3...cxd5 4.g4
  - **Rubinstein Variation** B13
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 -> 3...cxd5 4.Bd3 Nc6 5.c3 Nf6 6.Bf4
- **Goldman Variation** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.Qf3
- **Maróczy Variation** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.f3
  - **Maróczy Gambit** B12
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.f3 -> 3...dxe4 4.fxe4 e5 5.Nf3 exd4 6.Bc4
- **Mieses Gambit** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Be3
- **Modern Variation** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2
- **St. Patrick's Attack** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.h3
- **Toikkanen Gambit** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.c4 d5 3.e5
- **Two Knights Attack** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.Nf3
  - **Mindeno Variation** B11
    1.e4 c6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Nf3 -> 3...Bg4
    - **Exchange Line** B11
      1.e4 c6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Nf3 Bg4 -> 4.h3 Bxf3
    - **Retreat Line** B11
      1.e4 c6 2.Nc3 d5 3.Nf3 Bg4 -> 4.h3 Bh5
- **Campomanes Attack** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Nf6
- **Edinburgh Variation** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 Qb6
- **Gurgenidze Counterattack** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 b5
- **Gurgenidze System** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 g6
- **Apocalypse Attack** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nf3 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.Ne5
- **Dinic Gambit** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nf3 d5 3.d3 dxe4 4.Ng5
- **Hector Gambit** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.Nf3 dxe4 4.Ng5
- **Main Line** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4
- **Panov Attack** B13
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4
  - **Gunderam Attack** B13
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 -> 4...Nf6 5.c5
  - **Fianchetto Defense** B14
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 -> 4...Nf6 5.Nc3 g6
    - **Fianchetto Gambit** B14
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 g6 -> 6.cxd5 Bg7
  - **Modern Defense** B13
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 -> 4...Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6
    - **Carlsbad Line** B13
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 -> 6.Bg5 e6
    - **Czerniak Line** B13
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 -> 6.Bg5 Qa5

- **Mieses Line** B13
  1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 -> 6.Nf3 Bg4
- **Reifir-Spielmann Line** B13
  1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 -> 6.Bg5 Qb6
- **Main Line** B14
  1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 -> 4...Nf6 5.Nc3 e6 6.Nf3 Bb4
- **Rasa-Studier Gambit** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3
- **Scorpion-Horus Gambit** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.d3 dxe4 4.Bg5
- **Ulysses Gambit** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nf3 dxe4 4.Ng5
- **von Hennig Gambit** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Bc4
- **Classical Variation** B18
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5
  - **Flohr Variation** B18
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.Nh3
  - **Main Line** B18
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4
  - **Maróczy Attack** B18
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.f4
  - **Spassky Variation** B19
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4 h6 7.Nf3 Nd7 8.h5
  - **Lobron System** B19
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4 h6 7.Nf3 Nd7 8.h5 Bh7 9.Bd3 Bxd3 10.Qxd3 e6 11.Bd2 N…
  - **Seirawan Variation** B19
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 -> 5.Ng3 Bg6 6.h4 h6 7.Nf3 Nd7 8.h5 Bh7 9.Bd3 Bxd3 10.Qxd3 Ngf6 11.Bd2…
- **Finnish Variation** B16
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 h6
- **Karpov Variation** B17
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7
  - **Modern Variation** B17
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 -> 5.Ng5
    - **Ivanchuk Defense** B17
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 5.Ng5 -> 5...Ndf6
    - **Kasparov Attack** B17
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 5.Nf3 Ngf6 6.Ng3
  - **Tiviakov-Fischer Attack** B17
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 -> 5.Bc4 Ngf6 6.Nxf6 Nxf6
  - **Smyslov Variation** B17
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 -> 5.Bc4 Ngf6 6.Ng5 e6 7.Qe2 Nb6
    - **Main Line** B17
      1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 5.Bc4 Ngf6 6.Ng5 e6 7.Qe2 Nb6 -> 8.Bb3
  - **Modern Main Line** B17
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nd7 -> 5.Ng5 Ngf6 6.Bd3 e6 7.N1f3 Bd6 8.Qe2 h6 9.Ne4 Nxe4 10.Qxe4
- **Advance** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.e5 Bf5 4.c3 e6 5.Be2
  - **Short Variation** B12
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 Bf5 4.c3 e6 5.Be2
- **Alekhine Gambit** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Bd3
- **Endgame Variation** B10
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.Nf3 d5 3.d3 dxe4 4.dxe4 Qxd1 5.Kxd1
- **Mieses Attack** B12
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Bd3 Nf6 4.e5 Nfd7 5.e6
  - **Landau Gambit** B12
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Bd3 Nf6 4.e5 Nfd7 5.e6

- **Bronstein-Larsen Variation** B16
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Nxf6 gxf6
- **Tartakower Variation** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Nxf6 exf6
  - **Perlis Line** B15
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Nxf6 exf6 -> 6.c3 Bd6 7.Bd3 O-O 8.Qc2 h6
- **Alien Gambit** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Ng5 h6 6.Nxf7
- **Forgacs Variation** B15
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Nf6 5.Nxf6 exf6 6.Bc4
- **Martian Gambit** B18
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Nd2 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5 5.Ng5 Bg6 6.N1f3 h6 7.Ne6
- **Panov-Botvinnik** B13
  1.e4 c6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bg5 dxc4 7.d5 Na5
  - **Herzog Defense** B13
    1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bg5 dxc4 7.d5 Na5

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> e5 -> Nf3 -> Bd3 -> h4
Black	d5 -> dxe4 -> Bf5 -> Bg6 -> e6

Three rules to remember

1. c6, d5, free the bishop, then ...e6 and ...c5.
2. Black plays ...c5 or ...e5 to free the position; White uses space, or an IQP attack in the Panov.
3. White wants a space edge and kingside pressure; Black wants safe development, then a pawn break.

Pawn structure in one line

Solid c6/d5 with a free light bishop (Classical) or a French-like chain (Advance). Black has no weaknesses and the endgame is comfortable.